

To Be a Hero

written by

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Production & Staging notes

Director's Note: The staging descriptions below reflect the playwright's original vision. These specifications are flexible and should be adapted to suit the specific venue, stage dimensions, and other technical capabilities.

Set & Location Guide

The play takes place across four main locations:

- *Tavern*
 - Should include at least three tables (preferably round ones)
 - A tall bar counter positioned stage right
 - A door on stage left that acts as the tavern entrance
- *Street*
 - Optional elements may include: background walls showing houses and lantern posts.
- *Axel's Safehouse*
 - One table and chair (can be repurposed from tavern scene)
 - A couch positioned somewhere in the center
 - Door stage left (same as Tavern)
- *Broken Blade's Hideout*
 - Door stage left (same as Tavern)
 - A large furniture piece positioned center stage (shelf, closet or something else large enough to hide actors behind).
 - Cage for the prison scene, if not possible then the prisoner can be restrained to a chair.

Main Roles:

AXEL (24-29) - An aspiring hero with a strong moral compass.

DUKE (18-25) - Axel's self-appointed sidekick and best friend. Funny, talkative, and charismatic.

VIV (21-28) - A young noblewoman. (Stage combat experience beneficial)

KEO (20-30) - A charismatic adventurer and shameless flirt.

STELLA (20-30) - A practical, intelligent adventurer.

WILLIAM (20-40) - Strong and loyal, but not particularly bright.

Supporting Roles

Waitress / Prisoner 1

Thug 1 / Patron 2

Thug 2 / Baker

Thug 4 / Patron 3

Thug 5 / Patron 1

Thug 3 – Large and physically imposing thug

Lark – Leader of the Broken Blades

ACT 1

SCENE 1: INT. TAVERN - NIGHT

A lively tavern. Music plays. At a nearby table, PATRON 1, PATRON 2, and DUKE play cards. Duke is winning by a large margin.

AXEL sits alone in a far corner, dressed in dark clothes with his hood up.

The door swings open. KEO, STELLA, and WILLIAM stumble in looking exhausted.

KEO

(Groaning)

Ugh... If I never eat jerky again, it'll be too soon.

WILLIAM

If I never eat again... I'll probably be dead.

STELLA

Your survival instincts continue to impress me.

WILLIAM

Thanks. They're real good at tellin' me when I need food.

STELLA

That's just being hungry.

WILLIAM

Yeah, my instincts are incredible.

They collapse into their seats

KEO

How much did we actually make this time?

STELLA

Fifty gold.

KEO

Oh, that's not bad.

STELLA

Thirty seven after expenses.

KEO

I... hate expenses.

Keo starts counting with his fingers

KEO (CONT'D)
 Thirty seven divided by three is-

WILLIAM
 Foooooooo!!!

KEO
 Hey, I'm mathing here.

WILLIAM
 And I'm starving here!

The WAITRESS approaches

WAITRESS
 Hi, what can I get you?

Keo looks at the waitress for a bit too long

KEO
 Hey...

KEO (CONT'D)
 Let's see... three ales, three beef stews and three slices of bread.

William looks over at the menu that Keo is holding.

WILLIAM
 Oh, and a chicken pie.

WAITRESS
 Good choice. That's one of our specialties.

WILLIAM
 Make that, two chicken pies then

KEO
 One is enough.

WILLIAM
 Aren't you going to have any?

Keo sighs

KEO
 Fine. Two pies.
 (Smiling at the waitress)
 Though, if the pie is bad, I'll have to find a better excuse to come back tomorrow and see you.

WILLIAM
 Three pies.

KEO

What? You just said...

Keo sighs again and looks at the Waitress

KEO (CONT'D)

Three pies.

WAITRESS

Anything else?

KEO

(glancing at William)

Make it four actually. And three rooms for the night.

Keo meets Waitress's gaze for a bit too long, then hands over the coin with a flirtatious smile

WAITRESS

Thank you.

KEO

Keep the change.

WAITRESS

That's very generous.

KEO

Your smile's worth a lot more than that.

She smiles more and leaves. Keo watches her go.

STELLA

Can you stop flirting with every waitress we meet?

KEO

I'm not flirting. Simply complimenting.

STELLA

What's the difference?

KEO

Whether I sleep alone tonight.

STELLA

You're disgusting.

Keo shrugs it off and gets out a stack of job notices. He goes through each one. William is still hungry and just "loses consciousness" until the food arrives.

STELLA (CONT'D)

Anything interesting?

KEO
 (Reading)
 Dire badgers in a cellar?

WILLIAM
 (still pretending to be
 unconscious)
 We can roast those.

STELLA
 No.

Keo goes to the next page.

KEO
 Potato thieves

WILLIAM
 We can fry them.

KEO
 Missing goat.

WILLIAM
 Lamb stew.

KEO
 Missing cat.

WILLIAM
 Don't eat cats.

KEO
 Three missing dogs.

STELLA
 This city's got a very specific problem.

KEO
 Someone's probably opening an underground zoo.

*Patron 2, at a nearby table, loses another hand. He
 slams his cards down. Duke casually collects the
 coins.*

DUKE
 Well, it was nice playing you gentlemen.

PATRON 2
 You mean robbing?

DUKE
 Now, now. Can a fellow be blamed for taking advantage of two
 drunks in a tavern?

PATRON 2

Oh, fuck off, wanker.

DUKE

Aye-aye, fucking meself right off.

Duke leaves. Keo, Stella and William are still going through the job notices. The waitress returns with three drinks.

KEO

Unknown monster in the forest.

STELLA

That sounds fun.

KEO

Pays terrible though.

(Beat)

Oh, this is interesting. A missing noble - Vivienne Rosston.

STELLA

Daughter of Lord Rosston?

KEO

Yeah. Reward's a thousand gold pieces.

WILLIAM

How many pies is that?

Stella takes the job notice.

STELLA

No.

KEO

What?! Why?

STELLA

Look at the date. This is five days old.

KEO

So?

STELLA

So, the lead's got cold and for a thousand gold every mercenary and idiot with a sword is already looking into it with a several day head start.

KEO

But a thousand gold-

STELLA

Is zero, if we don't find her.

KEO

Okay...

STELLA

What else is there?

Keo holds up a bunch of wanted posters.

KEO

A few wanted posters. Small-time wannabes, bandits, gang leaders, a couple of thieves...

(pauses, looking at the final notice in his hand)

And then there is Specter.

Patron 1 slowly turns around, listening in more closely.

KEO (CONT'D)

Five thousand gold pieces.

STELLA

Specter isn't real.

PATRON 1

Oh, but he is.

Patron 1 stands up and takes an empty seat at their table.

KEO

Can we help you?

PATRON 1

No, but I can help you, young man.

Keo and Stella exchange a look. Patron 1 leans in closer.

PATRON 1 (CONT'D)

You see, Specter is no ordinary man. He is a force of nature. They say he struck a bargain with something that dwells beyond this world, and since that night death has followed wherever his shadow falls.

KEO

Ahhh, cool... why are you telling-

PATRON 1

Nobles, merchants, generals, men protected by walls, gold, and armies, have all met the same fate. Powerful people have hunted him for years, raising his bounty higher with every corpse left in his wake, yet no one has ever brought him in. Some claim he cannot be found.

STELLA

Or he's a convenient excuse. People kill each other every day, greedy heirs, rival nobles, jealous lovers. If nobody finds the culprit, they'll sooner or later blame Specter.

PATRON 1

Aye, that's what sensible folk say. Until they start digging. Then they stop saying much of anything.

KEO

(Amused)

You're a dramatic drunk, you know that?

Patron 1 finishes his drink. Stella still looks sceptical.

STELLA

And how many of these stories have you personally verified?

PATRON 1

None, of course. But I've heard them from people who know things.

Stella rolls her eyes.

KEO

(to Stella)

Come on, I'm actually kind of intrigued.

Maybe! The stage darkens, the spotlight reveals the Specter entering the stage. Patron 1 narrates in the background as the murders/deaths are acted out.

PATRON 1

First came the High Judge of Rivermoor. Rich and powerful man. He was found dead in an alley, his purse and jewels were untouched. Because Specter doesn't kill for coin. Then Lord Whitemoor, a beloved man who built schools and orphanages. He was found dead in his own bed. Guards and servants didn't hear as much as a squeak when Specter slit his throat and disappeared. Then came the Grand Marshal's son. Butchered alongside six of his guards on the high road. Again, nothing was looted. Even the horses were left untouched.

KEO

Oh, I heard of that one actually.

STELLA

It's not uncommon for bandits to lurk outside the city.

KEO

Yeah, attack and not steal anything?

PATRON 1

The city watch grew desperate. They assigned Captain Dorian to hunt that ghost. A week later Dorian and his men were found dead in some warehouse. Their eyes had been gouged clean out of their skulls.

WILLIAM

Why?

PATRON 1

Because they'd seen Specter's face.

STELLA

Look, it's a great ghost story, but I still don't see how any of this helps us.

PATRON 1

Patience, young lady. You see my throat's gone dry from all the talking.

He points to his cup and shows that it's empty

STELLA

Forget it, we're not buying you-

KEO

Another round for my friend here.

Stella gives Keo a stern look.

KEO (CONT'D)

What? Let's humour him. Consider it like buying information.

The Waitress enters and pours a drink for Patron 1.

PATRON 1

Appreciate it. That was very wise of you.

(beat)

Eventually, the bounty on Specter got so high, that city criminals wanted to claim it for themselves. There was this famous cutthroat-

KEO

Let me guess. He's dead.

PATRON 1

Found yesterday morning in his own hideout, along with nine of his men. No witnesses, doors still barred from the inside.

(takes a long swig)

Ned Finch was his name.

KEO

That rings a bell.

STELLA

His brother is the leader of the Broken Blades.

KEO

Oh! *Lark* Finch. I imagine he isn't taking the loss too well?

PATRON 1

He isn't. Word is *Lark's* out for blood. Rallying every thug to find *Specter*.

KEO

Unless, of course, *Specter* finds him first.

(realizing)

Oh, so *Lark* is our lead. We're not gonna chase a shadow, we're gonna find its next target. Then *Specter* will show up eventually.

PATRON 1

You've got a sharp wit on you, young man.

STELLA

No, thank you.

Everyone looks at her.

STELLA (CONT'D)

If even half of this is true, we'd be walking into a war between a ruthless criminal gang and a mythical ghost assassin. We're not taking this job.

KEO

So, finding *Vivienne Rosston* it is?

STELLA

Do you not listen? Everyone else is already looking for her.

KEO

We're better than everyone else.

STELLA

Ugh, fine.

(Standing up)

I'm going to bed. Tell the waitress to send the food to my room.

Stella leaves stage right.

KEO

(To William)

She does know *I'm* the leader... right?

William shrugs. Keo stands and turns to Patron 1.

KEO (CONT'D)

You wouldn't happen to know anything about this Vivienne Rosston?

Patron 1 shakes his head.

KEO (CONT'D)

Oh well, thanks anyway. It was entertaining.

He leaves and tells the waitress to bring the food to their rooms.

BAKER enters. He approaches Axel's table. Axel deliberately avoids eye contact, trying to appear cool and mysterious.

BAKER

Um, hi, are you Axel?

AXEL

(hero voice)

Who is asking?

BAKER

My name's Ralph. I own a bakery a few streets from here. People said you might be able to help me.

AXEL

People say a lot of things.

BAKER

...Right. Well, I have a problem. This... gang has been extorting local businesses around here. They want me to pay for "protection". But I can't afford their fee.

AXEL

The Broken Blades?

BAKER

Yes, them.

Baker sets eight gold pieces on the table.

BAKER (CONT'D)

I know it isn't much, but this is everything I can offer.

Axel stares at the coins.

BAKER (CONT'D)

Is that enough?

AXEL

What do you think I should do?

BAKER

Get rid of them?

AXEL

How?

BAKER

I don't know. Beat them up, threaten them.

AXEL

Temporary solution.

BAKER

Are you going to kill them?

AXEL

I don't kill

BAKER

Then what?

AXEL

Let's look at the facts. The Broken Blades have dozens of armed men, guards on their payroll, and enough influence to keep the authorities looking the other way.

BAKER

So there's nothing that can be done?

AXEL

I didn't say that.

Axel stands up, dramatically slides half the coins into his pocket, and leaves the rest on the table.

AXEL (CONT'D)

I'll take half now. The rest when the job is done.

BAKER

What are you going to do?

AXEL

Just leave it with me. For now, go home. Open your bakery as usual tomorrow. If they contact you, keep the rest of my pay and use it to settle things for the time being. I'll get in touch once everything is sorted.

The Waitress approaches and Axel hands her the coin like Keo did.

AXEL (CONT'D)

Keep the change.

WAITRESS

This is the exact amount.

Axel freezes, he tries to frantically get more coins from his pockets. Digs one out and places it onto the tray.

AXEL

Keep that then.

Axel leaves stage left. The Waitress stares after him, confused.

SCENE 2: EXT. STREET

Axel enters, Duke follows him a moment later.

DUKE

Hey, boss, wait up.

AXEL

(Normal voice)

Did you cheat?

DUKE

What?

AXEL

The card game with the two drunks. Did you cheat?

DUKE

Me? Cheat? Never.

A handful of playing cards slip from Duke's sleeve.

AXEL

Duke...

DUKE

Alright, maybe a little. But in my defense I didn't even need to! They were terrible. One of them kept showing me his cards.

AXEL

What did I tell you?

DUKE

(Quoting)

Good men don't steal from good people.

AXEL

Correct.

DUKE

But how do you even know who's good?

AXEL

You just have to assume they're good, until proven otherwise.

DUKE

That seems... difficult.

AXEL

Being good usually is.

DUKE

You know, for someone who needs money you have a *remarkable* talent for walking past easy coin, boss.

AXEL

Easy coin usually belongs to someone.

DUKE

Yeah, that's why you're broke.

Axel thinks for a moment.

AXEL

What would you buy if you had ten gold pieces?

DUKE

Booze?

AXEL

For ten gold?

DUKE

Lots of booze.

AXEL

You are a visionary.

DUKE

I know.

AXEL

If I had ten gold, I'd buy a good cloak.

DUKE

A cloak?

AXEL

You know. Presentation matters.

DUKE

(Sarcastically)

Planning to fight crime with style?

AXEL

No, but every great hero is recognized by their cloak.

Duke is not sure where this is going.

DUKE

Huh?

AXEL

Look, someday we'll make a name for ourselves. Until then, we need to earn people's trust.

DUKE

You can't buy booze with trust.

AXEL

No, but people's trust will bring more clients. And clients bring money and-

DUKE

-and money buys booze? Oh, right. I get it now.

AXEL

Duke... what did you get?

DUKE

Being famous gets you booze.

AXEL

(sighs)

This isn't about being popular. It's about showing others that someone actually cares. We're trying to be an example they can follow.

DUKE

Why do you even wanna be a hero?

AXEL

People need heroes. Someone who can protect, inspire and give hope.

DUKE

People need shit shovelers too.

Axel is caught off guard. He gives Duke a look.

DUKE (CONT'D)

You know, someone who can clean shit... and stuff.

AXEL

Ok, we'll buy you a shovel tomorrow.

Duke grins. They continue walking. Axel is deep in thought.

DUKE

Boss?

AXEL

Yeah?

DUKE

What would you do if you were really rich?

AXEL

Help people.

DUKE

You're kind of already doing that.

AXEL

No, I mean really help people. No fees, no rewards. Just helping because I can.

DUKE

That's very noble of you.

(beat)

I'd buy a gun.

AXEL

A gun?

DUKE

Yeah, if I become rich enough to buy a gun, I'm making sure everyone knows it.

AXEL

You could buy a mansion instead.

DUKE

Them guns are powerful though. You should get one too.

AXEL

Why would I want to buy a gun?

DUKE

Because it'd make your life easier. You could take on a dozen bandits at once.

AXEL

I'd rather not solve problems with violence.

DUKE

It's not just that, it's reputation, like you said. Imagine walking into a tavern with one of those on your hip. Nobody would mess with you.

AXEL

That is the kind of reputation I'm trying to avoid.

DUKE

Well, I'm not. You can be the inspiring hero. I'll be the scary one.

AXEL

That's not a thing.

DUKE

Sure is, just made it up myself.

AXEL

Heroes don't hurt or scare people.

DUKE

Alright...

(beat)

Where are we going, by the way?

AXEL

Looking for the Broken Blade thugs.

DUKE

Ah, Ralph, the baker.

AXEL

Yep, the baker.

DUKE

What's the plan? Beat them up?

Axel shakes his head

DUKE (CONT'D)

Threaten them?

Axel shakes his head again

DUKE (CONT'D)

Break their legs?

Axel stays silent.

DUKE (CONT'D)

You're going to talk to them, aren't you?

AXEL

Not exactly.

DUKE

Boss...

AXEL

Okay, yeah. That's exactly what I'm gonna do.

DUKE

It's a stupid plan, just so you know.

AXEL

I know. Worked on you though.

Duke seems doubtful, but doesn't voice his concerns. They continue walking until suddenly, a SCREAM echoes from somewhere offstage, followed by a thud.

Both freeze. Axel and Duke immediately sprint toward the sound.

EXT. ALLEYWAY

THUG 1 and THUG 2 hover over an injured, unconscious woman. Axel and Duke enter quietly from stage left.

THUG 1
(panting)

Is it her?

THUG 2
Think so. Quick, grab her and lets go

THUG 1
(goes to grab her, hesitates)
What if she's not really unconscious?

THUG 2
What? Do it or I'll break your-

At the same time Axel and Duke slip behind the thugs and knock them out.

DUKE
She's breathing. Badly hurt though, bleeding from the left shoulder, and there's heavy bruising on her face and arms.

Shouts are heard nearby. More thugs are closing in.

THUG 3
(offstage)

That way!

AXEL
Pick her up, we're leaving. I've got some supplies at the safehouse.

DUKE
What about Ralph, the baker?

AXEL
That can wait. We help her first.

SCENE 3: INT. AXEL'S SAFEHOUSE

Axel finishes bandaging Vivviene/VIV, who's still unconscious on the couch/bed. Nearby Duke is snacking on some nuts/jerky/biscuits from food pouch/jar.

AXEL

That was a strange wound, but the bleeding's mostly stopped. No fever, and I don't think anything's broken.

Duke is smiling to himself.

DUKE

(Grinning)

Boss...

AXEL

What?

DUKE

Is it your first time having a girl over?

AXEL

Why? Are you jealous?

DUKE

Maybe a little.

Duke takes another bite and talks with a mouthful

DUKE (CONT'D)

Why do you think those thugs were after her?

AXEL

No idea. We can ask when she wakes up.

Duke steps closer to Viv to examine her.

DUKE

Think she's dangerous?

AXEL

She's unconscious.

DUKE

Yeah, still. She looks like danger to me.

Duke notices the bandages.

DUKE (CONT'D)

Hey, you even used the good bondage stuff.

AXEL

What?

DUKE

You never use good bondages on me.

Viv groans. Duke and Axel don't notice.

AXEL

It's bandages. And you never needed them.

DUKE

I got stabbed at the tavern last month.

AXEL

It was a splinter.

Viv snaps open her eyes and looks at the two of them.

DUKE

Well, do you know how painful splinters-

Viv screams, Duke flinches back. Viv gets off the couch and throws a pillow at Axel.

VIV

Get away from me. Help! Somebody help!

DUKE

Calm down, lady. We are helping.

She picks up a mug and throws at Duke

DUKE (CONT'D)

Ouch, fu... Why do I get the mug??

Viv moves further backstage away from them

AXEL

(Makes his voice deeper)

We're not going to hurt you.

DUKE

Seriously though. Why the mug? There was another pillow right there.

AXEL

Duke, please.

DUKE

What? She mugged me!...in my house.

She pulls out a knife from her boot.

VIV

I said, stay away!

AXEL

(Looking at Duke, normal
voice)

How does she have a knife?

DUKE

What are you looking at me for? You bonded her!

VIV

You what?

AXEL

You carried her!

DUKE

Well, sorry I was too busy running away from armed thugs.

Axel sighs.

AXEL

(sighs, deep voice again)

Alright, let's calm down. Listen, we're trying to help you. We saved you from those thugs. But I understand, if you still don't trust us. Nobody's keeping you here. The door's right there. You're free to leave whenever you want.

Viv still hesitates.

DUKE

I don't think she heard you. She's probably deaf, or like stupid or something.

VIV

I heard him.

DUKE

Oh, so stupid then.

AXEL

You're not helping.

(To Viv)

You're safe here, I promise. Now let's put the knife down.

VIV

What's wrong with your voice?

AXEL

What do you mean?

DUKE

Haha, boss, you're doing the hero voice again.

AXEL

(Still deep voice)

No, I'm not.

VIV

Yeah you did it again.

AXEL

Can we not...

(sighs, goes back to normal
voice)

What's your name?

*Viv lowers her knife and sits down, still gripping it
tightly.*

VIV

(Hesitantly)

Vivienne.

Duke has just had a revelation and is shocked

AXEL

Nice to meet you, Vivienne. I'm Axel. This is Duke.
Can you tell us why those thugs were chasing you?

VIV

I'm not entirely su—

DUKE

HOLY SHIT! Vivienne? The missing noble girl! She's the
daughter of Lord Rosston.

AXEL

Is that true?

Viv nods

DUKE

Boss, there's like a thousand gold reward for finding her! We
just hit a jackpot, we're like super rich now.

AXEL

Duke, calm down.

Duke stuffs biscuits in his mouth.

AXEL (CONT'D)

(to Vivienne)

Do you wanna tell us what happened to you?

Viv doesn't reply.

AXEL (CONT'D)
Right, sorry. Are you hungry?

VIV
Yes...

AXEL
We've got some biscuits-

Axel turns and sees Duke holding the empty jar.

Awkwardly/guiltily he puts a half-eaten biscuit back in the jar and hands it to Axel.

AXEL (CONT'D)
(Sighs)
Just keep an eye on her, I'm gonna go get food.

VIV
I'm coming too.

AXEL
No.

VIV
Why not?

AXEL
Because bad people are still looking for you.

VIV
I've spent the last week locked in a cell. I'm not sitting here and letting you tell me where I can or can't go.

DUKE
Sorry princess, house rules.

VIV
Fine. Then I'll leave.

AXEL
That's not a good idea...

VIV
You said I'm free to leave.

DUKE
You did say that, boss.

Axel shoots him a look.

AXEL
Fine, you can leave. But don't say I didn't warn you.

DUKE

Wait, don't leave. What about the reward?

Viv is walking towards the door. Axel is taking a seat, trying to look unbothered.

DUKE (CONT'D)

There goes a thousand gold.

AXEL

...

DUKE

After we went through all that trouble to save her too.

Viv keeps walking.

DUKE (CONT'D)

You know, those thugs looked pretty determined.

(louder)

Poor girl. They'll likely break her legs this time, just to make sure she doesn't run away again.

Viv hesitates, but reaches for the door/about to leave the stage.

DUKE (CONT'D)

If only there were some brave hero who could've prevented such a tragedy.

AXEL

(groans)

Ugh, wait!

Viv turns around

AXEL (CONT'D)

Alright, you can come with us. On one condition.

VIV

What is it?

SCENE 4: INT. TAVERN

The Waitress is cleaning up behind the bar. Patron 1 is still in the tavern, now talking to PATRON 3 about this mysterious Specter.

PATRON 3

Is that true?

PATRON 1

Every single word.

PATRON 3

And nobody ever caught this Specter?

PATRON 1

Nobody even got close. I'm telling you, Specter is no ordinary man. He's a ghost... a force of nature.

(Finishes a drink)

Everyone who went after him ended up in the gutter sooner or later.

PATRON 3

Really?

PATRON 1

Of course. There was this one bloke. Captain Dorian. Dispatched specifically to catch Specter.

Waitress passes the table

PATRON 1 (CONT'D)

Hey, lass. Another drink, if you please?

Patron 1 pats himself down, "searching his pockets for money".

PATRON 1 (CONT'D)

Ah... shit, misplaced me coin somewhere.

PATRON 3

(Looking at the waitress)

This one's on me.

PATRON 1

(Grinning)

Thank you kindly.

The Waitress goes back behind the bar.

PATRON 1 (CONT'D)

Now, where was I?

PATRON 3

Captain Dorian.

PATRON 1

Ah, Dorian... mean bastard. Veteran of the war, one of the best the city had.

Axel, Duke and Viv enter the tavern. Viv is unrecognizable, a fake beard, oversized hat hiding her hair, and a bulky jacket. She keeps scratching at her face beneath the disguise.

VIV

This is stupid.

DUKE

Apologies, princess. Them's are the rules.

VIV

Stop calling me that. I'm not royalty.

DUKE

Aren't you important? Or have some posh title or something?

Axel heads to the bar to order food and drinks.

VIV

My father is a Count. You'd address him as "Your Grace." I'm his daughter, so it's "My Lady."

DUKE

Gotcha,

(slight bow)

My Lady.

VIV

You can't call me that in public anyway.

Duke and Viv find a table and sit.

DUKE

Right. You should have a nickname then. Did you have one as a kid?

VIV

No.

DUKE

Oh, that's too bad. Those are usually the best ones.

(Beat, thinking)

How about Vvv...Violence?

VIV

How about no.

DUKE

Okay then, let's think of something else. You're small, annoying, angry, stubborn and-

VIV

I'd choose your next words carefully.

DUKE

(a little taken aback)

-surprisingly threatening.

VIV

Remind me why I didn't just leave by myself?

DUKE

Because you enjoy my company way too much.

VIV

Keep telling yourself that.

DUKE

Madame Mug-shot?

Viv scratches her face under the beard.

VIV

Shut up.

DUKE

Aha, Lady Scratch-a-lot.

VIV

I hate you.

Axel comes back with three drinks

AXEL

What did I miss?

DUKE

Nothing. We're bonding.

Viv aggressively snatches her mug - Duke interrupts

DUKE (CONT'D)

Wow, easy there. You sure you know how to use those?

Viv ignores him and takes a sip. Then coughs

VIV

(Yuck sounds)

Ewhh... Tastes like piss.

Duke takes several gulps and exhales with satisfaction.

DUKE

That's how you know it's good.

AXEL

So, do you want to tell us what happened to you?

VIV

I was returning home after visiting my aunt. My carriage was ambushed by bandits. My guards were killed. My maid and I were taken and held in a cell somewhere in this city.

AXEL

How long ago?

VIV

About a week, maybe longer. I couldn't tell without windows.

AXEL

Any idea why they wanted you?

VIV

I don't know. Political leverage, ransom, blackmail.

AXEL

If it was ransom, they would've contacted your father, and there wouldn't be the job notice.

VIV

I know, that worries me too.

AXEL

How did you escape?

VIV

They got too careless.

AXEL

You're not answering the question.

VIV

One of them left the cell open. I snuck out when most of them were sleeping.

DUKE

(interrupting)

How about Beardzilla?

VIV

Can your jokes get any worse?

DUKE

Hey, it's been a long night, I'm tired and still sober.

AXEL

Did you see anything while escaping? Street names? Landmarks?

VIV

No. It was dark. I just ran.

AXEL

Did you hear any names, or remember anyone's faces?

VIV

Nothing useful. Their faces were covered.

AXEL

Okay.

(beat, thinking)

I think we should get you home soon. I'll arrange a carriage to your father's estate.

VIV

What? No.

Axel looks confused

VIV (CONT'D)

Alice is still there.

AXEL

Your maid?

VIV

Yes. And I'm not leaving without her.

AXEL

Viv, we can't risk you staying here any longer than necessary.

VIV

Aren't you supposed to be a hero? Don't you care what happens to her?

AXEL

I can save her later, for now-

VIV

No, not later.

(beat)

It's my fault she's in there. I'm not leaving her behind.

DUKE

Aww, she does have a heart.

VIV

Of course I do.

(beat)

Besides, she's the only person I trust with my hair.

DUKE

Was that a joke?

VIV

Spend too much time with you.

DUKE

Yeah, be careful. I'm contagious like that

AXEL

I understand she means a lot to you. But we don't know where she is, those thugs are still looking for you and I've got other important work. We can't waste time right now.

VIV

I'll double the reward.

Silence. Duke turns toward Axel.

DUKE

Boss...

AXEL

Uh-huh?

DUKE

She said double.

AXEL

I heard her.

DUKE

That's a lot of money.

AXEL

It is a lot of money.

DUKE

Yeah, exactly.

AXEL

Fine, we're in.

VIV

Great, so what now?

AXEL

First food, then sleep. You look like you're about to collapse. Duke and I will scout the streets and retrace the route where we found you. Maybe we can pick up a trail.

Axel and Duke go to the bar to get more drinks. Thug 1, Thug 2 and THUG 3 enter the tavern.

THUG 1

We're wasting our time, she's not here.

THUG 2

Boss said check everywhere. So we're checking everywhere.

Thug 3 pushes past Axel and Duke at the bar. Axel and Duke look at each other, recognizing Thug 1 and Thug 2.

THUG 3

My friends and I will need access to every room upstairs.

WAITRESS

I'm sorry?

THUG 3

I said hand over the keys, now.

WAITRESS

I have the master key, but guests aren't-

Thug 3 snatches the master key from her hand.

THUG 3

Much obliged.

(turning back to see other
thugs)

You two search down here. I'll check upstairs.

Thug 3 leaves the stage. Thug 1 and Thug 2 approach Patron 1 and Patron 3.

At the bar Axel and Duke discuss the plan

THUG 1

Evening fellas. We're looking for a young woman. Seen anyone suspicious?

PATRON 1

Oh, that depends.

Thug 1 and Patron 1 continue talking in the background.

AXEL

Well, shit. I told her she should've stayed home.

DUKE

Well, to be fair...

(beat)

Never mind, you're kinda right

AXEL

Yeah, I'm always kinda right.

DUKE

So what's the plan?

AXEL

Raining donkeys?

DUKE

Too messy, we don't want the city guard involved.

AXEL

Good point.

DUKE

What about confused penguins?

AXEL

Nope. No way.

DUKE

What? Why?

AXEL

That's too embarrassing.

DUKE

But it worked once.

AXEL

Yeah, and I'd rather die than do it again.

DUKE

That's a bit dramatic.

Moving back to the Thugs and Patron 1

PATRON 1

No, haven't seen anyone like that. Though I *did* hear a story about that strange lady in the city.

THUG 1

(Taking a seat)

What lady?

PATRON 1

Folks say she wanders the streets after dark like a ghost that forgot to stay dead.

THUG 1

Yeah?

PATRON 1

Oh yes. Beautiful thing too. Skin pale as the moon, hair dark as the night. A face so angelic it could-

Thug 2 slaps Thug 1 on the head.

THUG 2

Stop wasting time. Check on the next one.

They approach Viv.

THUG 2 (CONT'D)

Hey, old man. You didn't happen to see this girl around...

Focus shifts to Duke and Axel

DUKE

Stinky boots?

Axel gives him a look.

DUKE (CONT'D)

Yeah, you're right. That's too much.

(beat)

Oh I know, Jealous Husband.

AXEL

That could work. I'll be the Husband.

DUKE

What? You were the husband last time. It's my turn to be insecure.

AXEL

That's because you were the husband twice before that.

DUKE

Boss, you have zero theatrical restraint. My jaw is still clicking from last time.

Axel thinks it through, then sees Viv in trouble.

AXEL

Ok, fine.

Focus shifts onto the Thugs.

THUG 2

Hey, I'm talking to you.

Thug 2 notice pulls her beard/hat away. At the same time Axel and Duke execute Jealous Husband.

DUKE

(Loud)

YOU!

Everyone turns towards Duke

DUKE (CONT'D)

YOU FUCKED MY WIFE!

Duke punches Axel in the face. Axel stumbles backward and Thug 1 instinctively catches him.

Duke throws another punch, Axel ducks and the fist hits Thug 1 in the face. Thug 1 collapses unconscious.

THUG 2

You bastard...

Thug 2 pulls out his broken blade and goes after Duke. Axel knocks him out from behind.

AXEL

(Looking at Viv)

You're alright?

Viv nods. Duke picks up the blade from Thug 2. The end of the blade's tip is broken, a mark of the Broken Blades gang.

DUKE

Hey boss...

AXEL

(looking at the blade)

Ah... great.

VIV

What does that mean?

DUKE

Of all the gangs in the city, you got kidnapped by the Broken Blades?

VIV

And that's bad because...?

AXEL

They're the most ruthless crew in the city. You're lucky we found you when we did.

VIV

That's comforting.

DUKE

So, just checking. Are you still planning to talk to their leader about Ralph the baker?

AXEL

I don't know...

Thug 3 comes back.

THUG 3

What's all that noise?

Duke punches Axel again.

DUKE

YOU FUCKED MY WIFE!

He pushes Axel towards Thug 3 and throws another punch. Axel dodges and the punch lands directly on Thug 3's jaw. Thug 3's head barely moves. He grabs Duke by the throat.

THUG 3

Did you do all this?

Axel strikes him from behind. Thug 3 doesn't flinch, he backhands Axel across the room. Then he throws Duke to the ground.

DUKE

Boss...

AXEL

(Groaning)

Yeah?

DUKE

He's not going down.

AXEL

(after being punched 3 times)

You don't say.

Thug 3 recognizes Viv after her disguise was ruined.

THUG 3

You!

Axel and Duke attack together. Thug 3 swats them aside.

Viv runs, but Thug 3 cuts her off and grabs her arm.

VIV

Let me go.

THUG 3

You've been causing us a lot of trouble lately.

Stella enters stage right, the Waitress, William and Keo behind her. Stella points at Thug 3. Keo is trying to calm down the Waitress.

STELLA

He's still here.

William cracks his knuckles.

WILLIAM

Hey!

Thug 3 turns

WILLIAM (CONT'D)

The sign said, do not disturb!

William knocks Thug 3 out cold with one punch.

DUKE

Nice one, mate.

Axel, Duke and Viv immediately scurry off.

KEO

(Watching them leave)

Well... that wasn't suspicious at all.

He looks around then turns to the waitress.

KEO (CONT'D)

What happened here?

WAITRESS

(crying)

I don't know. They came in harassing people, then this one stole my keys and—

She leans into Keo. He gently puts an arm around her shoulders.

KEO

Hey, hey. It's alright. Everything's fine now. Let's get you some water.

Keo guides her towards the chair. She takes a seat and Keo comforts

Stella approaches Patron 1

STELLA

What happened?

PATRON 1

Lass, what happened here is a tale for the ages. It began with me telling this fella about Specter.

Stella heavily exhales

PATRON 1 (CONT'D)

Then these three men entered, well, one turned out to be a girl, and the other one plays cards like a devil-

STELLA

Stop. I have a headache as it is.

WILLIAM

(To Stella)

Hey, look. Their swords are broken.

STELLA

(realizing it's the Broken Blades)

Ah, crap. This night keeps getting better.

WILLIAM

Why?

STELLA

These idiots belong to Lark's crew.

WILLIAM

(Pretending to understand at first)

Ohhh...

(Beat)

Who's that?

PATRON 1

Only the leader of the most dangerous gang in the city. Him and his brother built a criminal empire through murder, extortion-

STELLA

Shut it!

STELLA (CONT'D)

(TO William)

Tie them up and make sure they don't wake up before the morning.

WILLIAM

(grinning)

Can do.

STELLA

I'm getting the city guard.

She turns to Keo. The waitress is sitting close to him.

WAITRESS

Is adventuring always like this?

KEO

Gods, no. Most days it's just walking, more walking and the blisters.

(beat)

But... It has its moments

WAITRESS

Such as?

He gently takes her hand.

KEO

Meeting interesting people...

STELLA

Keo...

KEO

Yeah?

STELLA

Behave.

SCENE 5: INT. AXEL'S SAFEHOUSE

Axel, Duke and Viv enter stage left.

VIV

Can you explain again, why you left those thugs alive? You had them unconscious twice.

DUKE

It's kind of our thing.

VIV

Not killing scumbags?

DUKE

Pretty much.

VIV

That's insane, they-

AXEL

Duke and I aren't executioners, we don't cross that line.

VIV

They murdered my guards!

AXEL

Killing wouldn't bring them back.

VIV

Of course it wouldn't, but it would prevent more people getting hurt.

AXEL

We don't kill, we save people.

VIV

Sometimes you have to kill to save someone.

AXEL

Then you're doing it wrong.

VIV

Wrong? This whole thing wouldn't have happened if you killed those thugs back in the alleyway, when you had the chance.

AXEL

You don't know that.

VIV

I DO!

Tense silence.

VIV (CONT'D)

You said it wasn't safe for me to stay in the city or go outside. Yet you let those men walk away after everything they've done, after they saw our faces. All of them are going to be looking for us now!

Axel turns away from Viv.

VIV (CONT'D)

Say something!

(beat)

You can't keep pretending to be a hero, clinging to the fantasy where everyone lives by morals and fairy-tale rules. That's not how the real world works. In the real world people die. They kill. They betray and hurt each other! You hide behind your ideals to avoid making the hard choices. You use your morals to justify your inaction. But the truth is, you're just weak. You're a coward who's too afraid to do what needs to be done!

Axel grips the back of the chair tightly, as if about to throw it. He stops himself, turns to look at Viv for a moment, then exits stage left.

Viv takes a seat on the couch.

VIV (CONT'D)

Ugh, he is just so unbelievably naive.

DUKE

I used to think this too, you know.

VIV

What?

DUKE

The whole... killing thing.

(beat, thinking)

Killed my dad when I was thirteen. Cruel bastard, he was. Used to beat me and my brother every day. One night, he went too far and then...
I was the only one left to beat.

VIV

If you'd killed him sooner, your brother would've lived.

DUKE

Yeah, maybe. I've thought about that plenty. The thing is... I still remember the look on my dad's face when he died. Not because I felt guilty. Because I didn't.

(beat)

It felt so easy, so right to do it.

And that kind of scares me.
It should bother me shouldn't it? I should be horrified at what I'd done.
Instead, part of me is glad.
Sometimes I wonder if that's how he felt when he beat us.
Whether that's where it starts. You do it once, tell yourself they deserved it... then the next time gets easier. And the next.

VIV

You really think killing a monster makes you one?

DUKE

I dunno, but since then...

(Beat)

I've hurt people, Viv. Done plenty of things I'm not proud of. Things I can't take back.

Beat

DUKE (CONT'D)

Then I met Axel. Tried to rob him actually.
We ended up fighting, and he beat the shit out of me. For a moment I felt like I was back home. Except when it was over, Axel looked at me like he was sorry. He could've handed me over to the city guard, or left me bleeding in the ditch. Instead he bought me lunch, clean clothes and even paid for my medicine. Who does that?

VIV

Someone stupid.

DUKE

No. You're wrong about him. He's not stupid... and he's not weak or a coward either.
I grew up knowing those things firsthand.
But he... it takes a lot of strength to be a man like him. Looking at a person who's given you every reason to hate them and refusing to become like them.
Best man I've ever met, though painfully embarrassing and dumb at times.

Viv chuckles

DUKE (CONT'D)

I don't think I'm a good person, but I'm trying to do better. And that started after I met him. He saw something worth saving in me, even when I couldn't.

VIV

You know, you're a lot smarter than you look.

DUKE

Yeah, the handsome guy in the mirror tells me that every morning.

Viv smiles

DUKE (CONT'D)

What about you? Miss your family?

VIV

I don't really wanna talk about it.

DUKE

Fair enough.

Though I was mostly going to ask if you had a cute younger sister who happens to be into Dukes.

VIV

No, but I do have a dog, who's into cheap charm and bad jokes.

DUKE

Rude... Funny, but rude.

VIV

(Smiling)

Sorry.

DUKE

For the record, my jokes are excellent.

VIV

What about Axel? Why is he like that?

DUKE

That's not my story to tell.

Axel comes back, looking serious.

AXEL

Alright. Here's the plan. Duke and I are going to the Broken Blade hideout tonight.

(looking at Viv)

And you're staying here.

VIV

I'm not just gonna-

AXEL

This is non-negotiable. You stay here, or we tie you up and send you home.

Viv tries to object, but changes her mind.

AXEL (CONT'D)

The men from the tavern wouldn't have had time to report back. As far as their boss knows, Viv never met us.

DUKE

Why tonight? We've all had a pretty long night.

AXEL

Yes, and so have they. Most of them should be out searching for Viv right now. That leaves fewer guards at the hideout, and the ones who stayed must also be tired and careless.

DUKE

How are we getting inside?

AXEL

I'll get to that. First, I need to know if anyone has an issue with the plan.

VIV

No.

DUKE

You know me.

AXEL

Good.

SCENE 6: INT. BROKEN BLADE'S HIDEOUT

NOTE: Thugs 1, 2, and 3 are different characters from the tavern thugs, but they are played by the same actors. All thugs in the hideout wear masks.

THUG 4 and THUG 5 are inside the hideout guarding the entrance. Both of them are wearing masks to cover their faces.

Awkward silence for a few seconds.

THUG 4
Did you hear that noise?

THUG 5
No.

THUG 4
There it is again.
(beat)
I'm telling you, there are rats in the walls.

THUG 5
(nodding)
Uh-huh.

THUG 4
I told Kettle we should get a cat.
(beat)
He said we can't, cuz someone is allergic. I mean do you even know how disgusting it is having rats in the hideout?

THUG 5
Yeah.

Awkward silence.

THUG 4
Man, why do I get stuck on door duty?

THUG 5
Because, someone has to guard the door.

THUG 4
It's dumb. I wanna be out there catching that girl.
(beat)
You think it's true what they say about her?

THUG 5
Dunno.

THUG 4
Hey, do you wanna hear a joke?

THUG 5
Not really.

THUG 4
Knock knock.

Thug 5 remains silent.

THUG 4 (CONT'D)
Come on, you're supposed to say "Who's there".

THUG 5
Why?

THUG 4
(Sigh)
Ah, forget it.

Another moment of awkward silence. Then knock on the door. Thug 4 goes to check who's there.

THUG 4 (CONT'D)
Who's there?

DUKE
(Deep voice)
Hatch.

THUG 4
Hatch who?

DUKE
Bless you, now open up.

Thug 5 chuckles. Thug 4 is annoyed.

THUG 4
What? No. I meant who the hell is Hatch?

DUKE
New recruit. Sugma hired me last week.

THUG 4
Who's Sugma?

DUKE
Sugma balls. Now, open the damn door.

Thug 5 laughs

THUG 4
You think that's funny, huh?!

Thug 4 unlocks and yanks open the door.

THUG 4 (CONT'D)

(Furiously)

I'm gonna open your damn skull, you punk-

Duke punches him in the face. Thug 4 collapses. Duke enters, Thug 5 pulls out his blade and charges Duke. Duke tries to talk to Thug 5.

DUKE

(to Thug 5)

Woah, wait! Wait! I just want to talk! Let's be reasonable here, we really don't have to do thi-

Thug 5 hesitates, completely throwing off his momentum, confused by the sudden surrender.

As Duke gets closer to Thug 5, he sucker punches him in the chin.

Axel enters and stares at Duke for a moment.

DUKE (CONT'D)

What?

AXEL

Nothing, just can't believe it worked.

DUKE

Yeah, told you it was faster than through the window.

AXEL

Alright, come on, let's move.

Axel and Duke exit stage right.

Stage darkens.

Transition Sequence

Axel and Duke enter stage left.

AXEL (CONT'D)

Did you hear that?

DUKE

Yeah, the guy was right about the rats in the walls.

Axel grabs Duke and pulls him behind the shelf/furniture piece.

Three thugs enter stage right.

THUG 1

They went that way!

The thugs leave. Axel and Duke step out of hiding.

DUKE

They're onto us. What's the plan?

AXEL

Let's split up. You find Alice. I'll keep them busy.

DUKE

You sure? There's a lot of them.

Axel puts the hood on.

AXEL

(deep voice)

A hundred more might have made it a fair fight.

DUKE

(sarcastically)

This was... kind of nice actually.

AXEL

That bad, huh?

DUKE

A little corny, yeah.

*Three thugs are heard offstage "Check the next room",
"Keep moving"*

AXEL

Go, quick!

Duke hides again behind the furniture. Axel moves into the open. Three thugs re-enter from stage right and spot Axel. Axel bolts off stage left. The thugs chase him. Duke slips out of hiding and exits in the opposite direction.

Lights dim.

Axel/Hooded Figure crosses from stage right to left, followed by the thugs.

*Then another **Hooded Figure/Specter** appears from stage right, thugs re-enter from the left. They attack the Hooded Figure.*

Thugs begin to lose the fight and attempt to retreat, shouting to each other.

The Hooded Figure cuts off their escape and attacks with a series of strikes. Moments later, all the thugs lie dead on the ground.

(Fight choreography's open to interpretation, but the scene must end with all thugs dead.)

Transition Sequence

PRISONER 1/Alice is held in a cage at center stage (or tied to a chair), depending on staging.

Three masked thugs guard the room.

Duke runs in wearing a disguise, his face is also masked.

DUKE

There you are. Come on. We've got a situation.

THUG 1

Who are you?

DUKE

Don't worry about it. Your presence is no longer required here. A breach's been flagged at the east access point. They need backup. Now.

Thugs look confused at each other.

DUKE (CONT'D)

(sighs)

Kettle's losing his shit. Move!

Thugs run offstage. Duke opens the cage to free prisoner 1.

DUKE (CONT'D)

Alright, let's get you out of...

She cowers back, shaking

DUKE (CONT'D)

Hey, hey, it's ok - I'm here to save you.

He takes off his mask.

DUKE (CONT'D)

Alice right? Your lady sent us.

PRISONER 1

I'm Vivienne...

DUKE

Huh?

The thugs enter from stage right and left.

THUG 1

Hey!

DUKE

Ah shit.

Transition Sequence*Lights dim****Cage/chair must be cleared from the stage.****Four thugs (1-4) enter stage right. Then Hooded Figure/Specter appears from the opposite side.**The thugs attack, trying to flank him. Thug 2 panics and hides behind a piece of furniture.**The Hooded Figure/Specter moves fast, cutting down the remaining thugs one by one. Within moments, they lie dead on the ground. The Hooded Figure/Specter leaves the stage.**Lights brighten.**Axel enters and freezes at the sight of the bloodshed. Bodies still lie scattered across the floor. He takes the hood off and is visibly shocked.*

AXEL

What the hell?

*In this confused moment Thug 2 sneaks up on Axel and knocks him out from behind.***Transition Sequence***LARK stands in the middle of the stage, holding a gun. Thug 3 is right behind him.**Thug 2 drags Axel in from stage left. Axel's hands are tied up.*

LARK

Did you find her yet?

THUG 2

No. But we found this one. Playing dress-up.

LARK

Who might you be?

AXEL

(Hero voice)

My name's irrelevant. I've come to bargain with you.

LARK

Oh yeah?

AXEL

The local businesses you're extorting are under my protection now.

Beat, Lark laughs

LARK

Oh, I like this one.

Lark punches him across the face. Axel recovers from the punch

AXEL

Edgar Moore.

LARK

Hmm?

AXEL

New captain of the city guard. Your man on the inside. I imagine if he disappears, things get inconvenient for you.

LARK

You trying to threaten me?

AXEL

I'm offering you a deal. Agree to my terms, or he dies tonight.
Losing him costs you more than what you make from your extortions.

LARK

You think I built my business on men like Edgar Moore?

AXEL

I think you maintain it with them.

Lark smiles and thinks for a moment. He punches Axel again.

LARK

(To Thug 2)

Take him away, we're done.

Thugs begin dragging Axel off stage.

AXEL
You're making a mistake.

LARK
(To Thug 3)
Keep looking for the girl.

AXEL
You're too late. You'll never find her.

LARK
Wait!

AXEL
Vivienne is safe. I sent her home.

LARK
Vivienne never left her cell.

AXEL
What?

LARK
She's still in the basement, been there all night.

AXEL
But the girl you're searching-

Lark punches Axel in the face again.

LARK
Get him out of here, make it hurt.

Thug 2 and Thug 3 drag Axel away.

Transition Sequence

Axel, Thug 2 and Thug 3 enter stage right. Thug 4 is standing stage left.

Thug 2 forces Axel to his knees center stage and punches him. Thug 3 joins in.

Axel falls to the ground, then they start kicking him.

Thug 4 suddenly collapses stage left.

THUG 2
(to Thug 3)
Go check on him.

Thug 3 approaches Thug 4. Thug 2 kicks Axel one more time.

Specter quietly appears from behind the furniture piece and slices Thug 2's throat.

Thug 3 notices blood on Thug 4.

THUG 3

He's bleeding. There's blood—

As he turns around, Specter is already on him, stabbing him several times.

Specter cuts Axel's bindings and lifts him up, dragging him by the arm toward stage left.

AXEL

No, wait! I have to get my friend.

Specter ignores the complaint and tries to drag him anyway.

AXEL (CONT'D)

Let me go, I'm not leaving him!

They struggle. Axel breaks free. Specter grabs him again. During the scuffle, Specter's hood falls back.

AXEL (CONT'D)

You...

VIV

Hey, hero...

Axel stumbles back. He looks at Viv, then at the bodies, then back at Viv again.

AXEL

I'm going back.

VIV

(Blocking his path)

You can't.

AXEL

(pulling free)

Duke's still in there.

VIV

Axel, look at me.

He doesn't. Viv blocks his path.

VIV (CONT'D)

They're expecting me, so they'll definitely be ready for you.

AXEL

Get out of the way, Viv.

VIV

You go back in there, you're as good as dead.

AXEL

Why do you care?

Viv hesitates to answer.

AXEL (CONT'D)

I can't leave him.

Axel pushes past Viv towards stage right.

VIV

I know...

Viv hesitates again, then quickly moves behind him and presses a white cloth against his face. Axel tries to resist, but falls unconscious after a few seconds.

VIV (CONT'D)

I'm sorry.

END OF ACT 1

—